

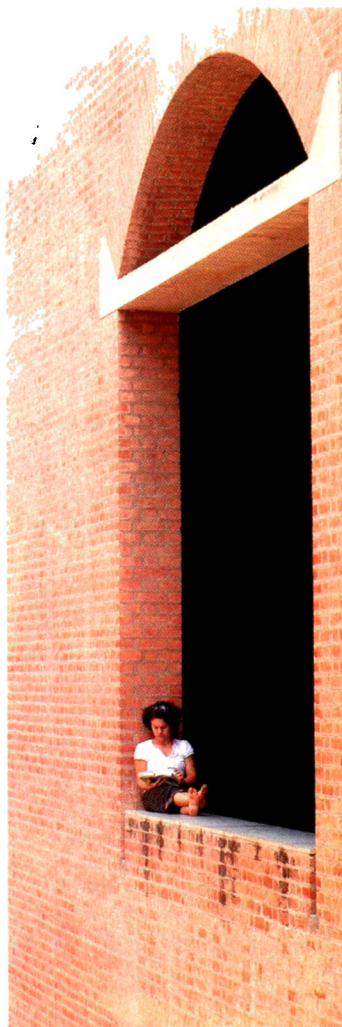
would soon offer management programmes in unconventional subjects such as politics and music as well.

With the metaphoric shrinking of the world, a top B-school cannot ignore providing international exposure to its students. An example is IIM-B which has tie-ups with several prestigious universities across the world. "We encourage students to either attend an exchange programme or intern with foreign firms to absorb their business models and ethics," says Ganesh N. Prabhu, professor, IIM-B.

But even as the number of MBA colleges soars—there are approximately 2,000 All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE) approved colleges—all luring students with the promise of hi-tech campuses and international placements, experts view this trend with utmost caution. An AICTE endorsement isn't enough and students are often duped into joining sub-standard institutes. So while six-figure salaries and first-class education might be taken or granted at top B-schools, the remaining offer dubious training and dismal placement offers. "To help students make an informed choice, accreditation of B-schools might help," suggests Singh.

Another worry is the lack of quality faculty. "We need to attract, develop, retain and expand the pool of

METHODOLOGY



The BUSINESS TODAY-Nielsen Survey was carried out in two phases. The first phase consisted of face-to-face interviews with 666 MBA aspirants and 279 HR recruiters. They were asked to arrive at top 30 B-schools. In the second phase, interviews were conducted with 134 MBA aspirants, 132 current MBAs, 110 recruiters, 109 young executives and 111 functional heads across 12 cities—Delhi (including NCR), Mumbai, Kolkata, Chennai, Lucknow, Ahmedabad, Pune, Indore, Hyderabad, Bangalore and Coimbatore.

These respondents then ranked the 30 shortlisted colleges on factors such as reputation, placement, faculty, teaching methodology, quality of placements and infrastructure. A brand equity result was arrived at each of these schools and the results were then compiled. BUSINESS TODAY is a part of the India Today Group and Nielsen is an independent marketing research organisation.

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SPECIALISATION IS THE BUZZ WORD WITH THE NEW-AGE MBAs. INSTITUTES ARE NOW OFFERING COURSES IN NICHE AREAS SUCH AS RETAIL AND AGRI-BUSINESS.

research-oriented faculty," says Ajit Rangnekar, dean, ISB. But the fact of the matter remains that unlike the West, research is not incentivised here in India. "Name one management book by an Indian in the last 50 years that has become a standard textbook in colleges worldwide," asks C.S. Venkata Ratnam, director,

International Management Institute, Delhi. But according to Prabhu, the problem lies not just with the lack of incentives but with the lack of appropriate exposure. "Till now, Indians published their papers in domestic journals which have a limited circulation. Also because the West was pretty wary about our writings. But

now that India has become a hot favourite, it should be easier for our researchers," he says.

The world is certainly micro-inspecting India. As the economy booms and big investors pump in the cash, greater skills and accountability would be expected of its current and future managers. The potential, thanks to a largely young population, is immense. And the B-schools have realised this. The zealous upgradation and a zero-error approach would certainly be the mantra adopted in the coming time. The big winner in the end is going to be the MBA aspirant.